1.0. Introduction & Vision :

“Our (Primary) School is at the Museum...”

In this school, teaching follows best primary education practice and delivers full core curriculum.

But.....every subject is explored in the context of an object, or selection of objects, from the collection.

The project aims to “start as we mean to go on”, reaping the riches of our extraordinary national collections and using the museums to look forwards, not backwards.....The project envisions enabling children (our nation’s living treasure) to absorb local collections (our nation’s cultural treasure) by osmosis; a constant weave of reference from object to curriculum offering a fundamentally different experience, qualitatively, from occasional visits.

Some attributes could include :

- Cultural Continuity / Identity / Citizenship; an understanding of “our” (“their...”) local regional / national collections and where that school and pupils sit relative to them
- a clear setting-to-rights of issues concerning exclusion in museums or cultural heritage
- making the museum part of local children's, and families’, daily life
- inspiring making and creativity; digital information is vital, but the physical knowledge embedded within objects bridges arts, sciences and humanities. Museum schools could be "MAKE(-ing)" schools - Museums As Knowledgable Environments, not (just...) places of Information
- looking backwards, seeking inspiration and accelerating forwards along axes suggested by the collections' parameters. Where do I come from? Where am I going to?
- efficiency- there are many common elements in the make-up of museums and schools
  - personnel - teaching, administrative, FM
  - classrooms; gathering space
  - cloakrooms, toilets, eating places
  - security, heat, light
- part resolving the grave shortage of primary places: many museums could, with simple re-ordering or extension, provide fit-for-purpose accommodation, representing capital cost value with onward sharing of running costs
- application in city, regional or rural areas, with differing cultural and community issues. Museum schools could be significantly different from each other, highlighting regional attributes whilst teaching common core curriculum
- contributing to the debate con the future role of museums and their resilience. As a bi-product of association, Museums could rise up some LA organisational hierarchies. Schools are legislatively required; museums not. The mutual strengthening and enrichment of operation could support Museums’ viability and sustainability
- delivering increased access to collections; with primary

Recent research shows links between Culture and Poverty (Andrews Report, Wales), and the need for world-class creative and cultural education for wellbeing of the population and the resurgence of a productive Britain (Warwick Commission).

This Action Research Project proposal seeks to experimentally place whole classes of primary school children for a prolonged period into local museums, assessing Learning and Social outcomes, amongst other parameters discussed above.

2.0. Action Research Project (ARP)
Project Objectives

We are planning to design a live project, where a partnership between a few Museums with local Primary schools is established. with an agreement to place one or two classes or year groups into the Museum for, say, a school term (nominally the winter term 2016 between New Year and Easter). During this time "school life will go on as normal", but the teaching plan for the core curriculum at that point i the year will be adapted to include interaction, across all subject matters, with the Museum's collection.

The activities and results of this new configuration will be carefully recorded, monitired and analysed, with a view to assessing realtive to the project's objectives.

The Objectives are namely:

1 to test the hypothesis that there can be beneficial Learning and Social outcomes for primary school children and their families, if they attend primary school in a museum;

2 to test the hypothesis that the national curriculum can be satisfactorily delivered in a (local) museum setting;

3 to identify the potential benefits in the mutual sharing of primary school and museum resources, eg

a) facilities maintenance and operations
b) energy costs
c) administrative/operational/Learning Staff costs
d) increase in (visitor/pupil) numbers in the museum; increase in occupied time; ie. overall efficiency of museum resource

4 to establish whether such a model of museum service delivery could simultaneously generate a strategy to provide further places as a contribution towards the UK's grave shortage of primary school provision

5 to prove a symbiotic strategy that could "rescue" some of the country's museums, currently struggling in terms of viability, resilience and sustainability.

We will need to put in place (schools and DEPS) Educational and (Museums) Learning support to assist in establishing the parameters of measurement and assessment for the specific objectives.

The project will be fully planned in detail in advance in collaboration with the school, teachers, governing bodies and parents, as well as with all relevant museum personnel.

3.0. Proposed Timings

3.1. We propose a 3-4 month period to "design" :

- the alterations or reconfiguration of museum spaces to house the school classes
- the outline plan of the curriculum to be taught during the live project aligned with the Collection, as appropriate
- the outline plan for the assessment parameters and methodology for live action research project measurement
- and complete all associated risk assessments both for the school (children) and the museum

We propose the 3-4 months' work is undertaken Spring/Summer 2015, with a view to securing all final detail and permission during the autumn term 2015. It os hoped that the live project could run in the Winter term (Christmas to Easter) 2016.

3.2. Live Action Research Project progress to date

Initial discussions with four museum service bodies, have suggested one or two classes could be accommodated for the project duration.

We have looked in some detail already at the nature of the collections in two of the four museums, and have provisionally established nominal classroom accommodation; toilet and catering provision; potential safe and secure playtime areas.

We are now at a stage where the plans need to be more fully discussed with the local school partners.

It is hoped that establishing the final set of School - Museum - King's partnership configurations can be completed in May 2015.

4.0. Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

Assessment parameters and assessment /reporting formats will need to be agreed with project partners and evaluators. In all cases the Action Research Project (ARP) must be vigilant in the observation and assessment of any unforeseen consequences or impacts.

KPIs to be finally defined might include:

4.1. Primary School : Children and Teacher/s

- children's performance (marks?) w.r.t. Curriculum/Key Stages
- significant differences between school-based and museum-based performance
- additional ease or support (or not!) felt by teacher in this environment
- happiness; contentment; inspiration felt by children
- benefits (or otherwise) that teacher considers available in museum setting
- parents/carers assessment of benefits or otherwise of museum setting

4**.2. Museum**

- increased use of facility : does the constancy of primary school presence improve numbers/efficiency/business plan?
- can a constant core curriculum delivery service sit satisfactorily or beneficially alongside regular shorter visit schools learning programme?
- are there beneficial Social and Learning outcomes from a museum perspective?

4.3. Themes to be included in the detailed design of the ARP assessment methodologies and definition of final KPIs

4.3.1 The Value of Learning in such a rich environment.

- Learning Outcomes must be assessed, but lines of inquiry might include:
  - the value of Haptic Learning associated with objects,
  - the inspiration and creativity associated with collections; the opportunity to make similar objects; consideration of the original motivation and craftsmanship behind objects in the collections

4.3.2. Families, extended families and intergenerational learning and support

- there is inevitably more family contact at the school (museum) interface with younger children, who need to be taken and collected; watched in activities, events and performances etc.
- taking primary children more into museum sites could mean they absorb the content of a whole collection over time. Could this lay a good foundation for return in-depth work in later schooling, work experience and training/apprenticeships in the sector?

- primary schools in local museums may engage older members of the family as well, spawning memory based projects and intergenerational programming
- with the extended family involved, could the co-location significantly help to build a sense of belonging, cultural continuity and values of citizenship?

4.3.3. Sharing Facility Resources

- Museums and primary schools have limited hours; combining the two may allow optimisation of hours across the week; the revenue aspects of business planning could be studied
- Facilities Maintenance (FM) staff; energy bills and common facilities (sanitary; catering etc.) could be more efficiently used
- there could be sharing of teaching and teaching support staff; administrative staff etc.

5.0. Summary status April 2015

With real interest and significant time having been invested by UK museums in Tyne & Wear; south Yorkshire; Wales and London, we hope to move to consolidation of the ARP proposal.

- confirmation of the School - Museum - King's partnerships is hoped for by the end of May 2015

- the detailed planning of the ARP is planned to continue through late spring / summer 2015

- final permissions from governing bodies, parents etc both in the schools and the museums would be sought in autumn 2015

- the live ARP is planned to run during the winter term New Year - Easter 2016

- he first draft report should be available June 2016